THE MAHABHARATA

The Great Epic of the Bharata Dynasty

Its story, its eighteen books, its people and its teachings

A 30-page illustrated overview

Overview of the Mahabharata

The Mahabharata is one of the two great Sanskrit epics of ancient India, the other being the Ramayana. Traditionally attributed to the sage Vyasa, it was composed and expanded over many centuries, roughly between 400 BCE and 400 CE. With around 100,000 verses (the Shatasahasri Samhita), it is among the longest poems ever composed, many times the length of the Iliad and the Odyssey combined.

At its heart is the story of a dynastic conflict between two branches of the Kuru family, the Pandavas and the Kauravas, culminating in the eighteen-day war at Kurukshetra. Around this core are woven countless side stories, philosophical discourses, myths and teachings on duty, politics, and liberation.

The epic describes itself with the line that what is found here may be found elsewhere, but what is not here exists nowhere else. It is organised into eighteen books called Parvas, with the Harivamsa often treated as an appendix.

Adi Parva: The Book of Beginnings

The first book introduces the narrative frame: the sage Vaishampayana recites the story to King Janamejaya, a descendant of the Pandavas, having learned it from Vyasa. It then traces the origins of the Bharata dynasty, starting with King Shantanu and the river goddess Ganga, whose son Devavrata later becomes Bhishma after taking a terrible vow of celibacy and loyalty to the throne.

Shantanu later marries Satyavati, whose sons die without heirs. Vyasa, her son by the sage Parashara, fathers Dhritarashtra, Pandu and Vidura through the widows and a maid. Dhritarashtra is born blind, and Pandu becomes king.

Pandu's wives Kunti and Madri bear the five Pandavas through divine boons: Yudhishthira, Bhima, Arjuna, Nakula and Sahadeva. Dhritarashtra and Gandhari have a hundred sons, led by Duryodhana. The book also covers the boys' training under Drona, the tournament where Karna appears, the lacquer-house plot at Varanavata, and Arjuna winning Draupadi at her svayamvara.

Sabha Parva: The Book of the Assembly Hall

After the Pandavas are given the barren region of Khandavaprastha, they transform it into the prosperous city of Indraprastha with the help of the architect Maya, who builds a marvellous assembly hall. Yudhishthira performs the grand Rajasuya sacrifice to declare his sovereignty. During it, Krishna is honoured first, and Shishupala insults him and is slain by Krishna's discus.

Duryodhana, visiting the hall, is deceived by its illusions, falls into a pool and is laughed at. Burning with humiliation and envy, he conspires with his uncle Shakuni.

Yudhishthira is invited to a game of dice, a pastime he cannot refuse and cannot play well. Against the cunning Shakuni he loses wealth, kingdom, his brothers, himself and finally Draupadi. She is dragged into the assembly and humiliated by Duksasana, and her questions about dharma go unanswered. The book ends with the Pandavas being sent into exile.

Vana Parva: The Book of the Forest

The longest of the narrative books after the Shanti Parva, the Vana Parva follows the Pandavas and Draupadi through twelve years of forest exile. Much of it is made up of stories told by sages to console and instruct them, including the tales of Nala and Damayanti, Savitri and Satyavan, and a condensed version of the Ramayana.

Arjuna travels to the Himalayas to win divine weapons. He pleases Shiva, who appears as a hunter, and receives the Pashupata weapon, and he spends time in Indra's heaven. Bhima meets his half-brother Hanuman, and also fights the demon Jatasura.

The book includes the famous Yaksha Prashna, in which a yaksha, who is Dharma in disguise, questions Yudhishthira after the other brothers die from drinking from his lake. Yudhishthira's wise answers restore them. It also contains the abduction of Draupadi by Jayadratha, and Karna's gift of his armour and earrings to Indra.

Virata Parva: The Book of Virata

In the thirteenth year of exile, the Pandavas must live unrecognised. If they are discovered, they must repeat the exile. They hide their weapons in a shami tree and enter the court of King Virata of Matsya in disguise.

Yudhishthira serves as Kanka, a courtier skilled at dice. Bhima becomes Ballava, the royal cook. Arjuna takes the guise of Brihannala, a eunuch dance teacher for the princess Uttara. Nakula tends horses as Granthika, Sahadeva tends cattle as Tantripala, and Draupadi becomes Sairandhri, a maid to the queen.

When the general Kichaka harasses Draupadi, Bhima kills him secretly. Meanwhile the Kauravas raid Virata's cattle, and Arjuna, retrieving his weapons, defeats the entire Kaurava army single-handedly with Prince Uttara as his charioteer. His identity is revealed after the term is complete, and Arjuna's son Abhimanyu marries Uttara.

Udyoga Parva: The Book of Effort

With exile over, the Pandavas ask for their share of the kingdom. This book chronicles diplomacy and the preparations for war. Envoys are exchanged, and both sides seek allies. Famously, Duryodhana and Arjuna both go to Krishna: Duryodhana chooses Krishna's vast army, while Arjuna chooses Krishna himself, unarmed, as his charioteer.

Krishna goes to Hastinapura as a peace envoy, asking for just five villages for the Pandavas. Duryodhana refuses to give even land the size of a needle's point. Krishna's attempt to take him captive in the assembly is met with the revelation of his universal form.

Kunti reveals to Karna that he is her firstborn son and begs him to join the Pandavas. Karna refuses out of loyalty to Duryodhana, but promises not to kill any Pandava except Arjuna. The armies, including those of many kings, assemble on the plain of Kurukshetra.

Bhishma Parva: The Book of Bhishma

This book opens the war and contains the Bhagavad Gita (chapters 25 to 42). Seeing his teachers and kinsmen on the opposite side, Arjuna loses heart and puts down his bow. Krishna's teaching on duty, action, devotion and knowledge restores his resolve.

Bhishma is the Kaurava commander for the first ten days. He fights with unmatched skill and the Pandava army suffers terrible losses. Rules of war are initially observed, such as fighting only in daylight and not striking those who surrender.

Because Bhishma has vowed not to fight a woman or anyone who was one, the Pandavas place Shikhandi in front of him. Arjuna shoots him from behind Shikhandi, and Bhishma falls on a bed of arrows. Granted the boon of choosing the moment of his death, he lies there until the sun turns northward.

Drona Parva: The Book of Drona

Drona becomes commander and tries to capture Yudhishthira. On the thirteenth day, Arjuna is lured away, and the Kauravas form the chakravyuha, a spiral formation. Abhimanyu, Arjuna's sixteen-year-old son, knows how to enter it but not how to leave. He fights heroically and is surrounded and killed by several warriors, against the rules of war.

Arjuna, enraged, vows to kill Jayadratha before sunset the next day or die. Krishna uses his power to create an apparent eclipse. Jayadratha emerges, believing the day to be over, and Arjuna beheads him.

The war moves into the night. The rakshasa Ghatotkacha, Bhima's son, wreaks havoc, and Karna uses his divine weapon on him, a weapon he had saved for Arjuna. Drona is finally killed after the false news that 'Ashwatthama is dead' is spread, causing the teacher to lay down his weapons.

Karna Parva: The Book of Karna

Karna takes command and chooses Shalya, king of Madra, as his charioteer. Shalya, secretly sympathetic to the Pandavas, taunts and demoralises him. Duhshasana is killed by Bhima, who fulfils his vow by tearing open his chest and drinking his blood after Draupadi's humiliation.

The duel between Karna and Arjuna is the book's climax and is the most anticipated of the war. Karna is weakened by multiple curses, including that he would forget the weapon mantras at the critical moment, and that his chariot wheel would sink in the earth.

When the wheel sticks, Karna asks Arjuna to wait, appealing to the rules of war. Krishna reminds him of the many times he and the Kauravas broke these rules. Arjuna kills him. The Pandavas then discover he was their elder brother, which devastates Yudhishthira.

Shalya Parva: The Book of Shalya

Shalya becomes the last commander of the Kauravas and is killed by Yudhishthira on the eighteenth day. Most of Duryodhana's brothers have already died, and his forces are nearly annihilated. Shakuni is killed by Sahadeva.

Duryodhana flees and hides beneath a lake using his powers. The Pandavas taunt him until he emerges to fight Bhima with maces. The duel is evenly matched until Krishna reminds Bhima of his vow to break Duryodhana's thigh, made after the dice game.

Bhima strikes below the navel, which is forbidden in mace combat, and Duryodhana falls. Balarama, who taught both fighters, is furious at this violation, but Krishna calms him. Duryodhana, dying, is left alone on the battlefield, still proud and defiant.

Sauptika Parva: The Book of the Sleeping Warriors

This short, dark book is set on the night after the war. Ashwatthama, Drona's son, finds the dying Duryodhana, who names him commander. Haunted by an owl's night attack on sleeping crows, Ashwatthama resolves to massacre the Pandava camp.

With Kripa and Kritavarma, he slaughters the sleeping army, including Draupadi's five sons and Dhrishtadyumna, the killer of Drona. The Pandavas themselves survive because they are elsewhere that night.

Ashwatthama flees and launches the Brahmashira weapon, and Arjuna launches his own in response. Vyasa intervenes, and Arjuna withdraws his, but Ashwatthama cannot, and directs it at the womb of Uttara. Krishna saves the unborn child, Parikshit, and curses Ashwatthama to wander in pain for thousands of years, losing the jewel on his forehead.

Stri Parva: The Book of the Women

The Stri Parva turns from battle to grief. Gandhari, Kunti, Draupadi and other women walk onto the battlefield, mourning the dead. The poetry of this book is among the most moving in the epic, as the women lament husbands, sons and brothers.

Dhritarashtra, enraged, embraces Bhima, and crushes an iron statue that Krishna had placed in his stead. He then repents his rage. Gandhari, who has blindfolded herself since her marriage, curses Krishna, saying that his own clan will destroy itself in thirty-six years. Krishna accepts the curse.

Kunti reveals the truth of Karna's birth, and the Pandavas perform funeral rites for him. The book is a profound meditation on the human cost of war, showing that victory brings sorrow as well as triumph.

Shanti Parva: The Book of Peace

The largest of the eighteen books, the Shanti Parva is a vast discourse on statecraft, ethics and liberation. Yudhishthira, overcome by guilt for the destruction of his kin, wants to renounce the world. Krishna, Vyasa and others persuade him to accept the crown and fulfil his duty.

He is taken to the dying Bhishma, who lies on his bed of arrows and instructs him. The teachings cover rajadharma (the duties of kings), apaddharma (conduct in times of emergency), and moksha dharma (the path to liberation).

Topics include the nature of justice, the structure of the state, taxation, diplomacy, the nature of the self, and many parables and dialogues. This book makes the Mahabharata not only a story but also an encyclopedia of ancient Indian thought on how to live and govern.

Anushasana Parva: The Book of Instructions

Bhishma continues his teachings to Yudhishthira, focusing on dharma in everyday life, ethics, charity, and duties of different social groups and stages of life. The book is largely made up of dialogues, tales, and rules on gift-giving, pilgrimage, fasting and rituals.

It contains the Vishnu Sahasranama, the thousand names of Vishnu, recited by Bhishma at Yudhishthira's request. This hymn remains one of the most widely chanted prayers in Hinduism.

When the sun begins its northward course, Bhishma gives up his life by his own will. His funeral is performed with great honour, and Ganga, his mother, mourns him. The Pandavas return to Hastinapura, and the war's long period of reckoning approaches its end.

Ashvamedhika Parva: The Book of the Horse Sacrifice

On Vyasa's advice, Yudhishthira performs the Ashvamedha, or horse sacrifice, to purify the kingdom and assert his rule after the war. A consecrated horse is released to roam freely, followed by Arjuna and the army. Any king who stops it must be fought or submit.

Arjuna's journey brings him into several battles, some against his own relatives and old friends, including his son Babhruvahana, whom he meets in a tragic conflict. The sacrifice also demonstrates reconciliation.

Along the way, the book contains the Anugita, in which Krishna repeats some of the Gita's teachings to Arjuna, who admits he has forgotten them. It also records the revival of the child Parikshit, whom Krishna brings back to life after he was stillborn due to Ashwatthama's weapon.

Ashramavasika Parva: The Book of the Hermitage

After fifteen years of rule under Yudhishthira, Dhritarashtra, Gandhari and Kunti choose to retire to the forest. Dhritarashtra, long overshadowed, finally accepts that he must renounce power. The Pandavas, particularly Yudhishthira, treat him with deep respect.

Kunti, who could have lived comfortably as queen mother, chooses to accompany her elders in the forest. Her decision shows her renunciation and her devotion to Gandhari.

Vyasa, by his powers, once allows the grieving elders to see the dead warriors who rise from the Ganga for a night. All reunite and reconcile before they disappear again. Soon after, the three elders die in a forest fire while engaged in meditation. The Pandavas mourn them and perform the last rites.

Mausala Parva: The Book of the Clubs

Thirty-six years after the war, ill omens appear in Dwaraka. As Gandhari had cursed, the Yadava clan, Krishna's own people, begin to fall into corruption and arrogance. A group of Yadava youths play a prank on visiting sages by disguising Samba as a pregnant woman, and the sages curse that he will give birth to an iron club that will destroy the clan.

The club is ground to powder and thrown into the sea, but the powder grows into reeds. At a festival at Prabhasa, intoxicated Yadavas quarrel and kill one another with these reeds, which turn into deadly clubs.

Balarama withdraws to the forest and gives up his life in meditation. Krishna, sitting in the forest, is struck by an arrow from a hunter named Jara and departs from the world. Arjuna arrives to find Dwaraka about to be swallowed by the sea.

Mahaprasthanika Parva: The Great Journey

Hearing of Krishna's passing, the Pandavas realise their time on earth is ending. Yudhishthira crowns Parikshit as king of Hastinapura, and the five brothers and Draupadi set out on a final pilgrimage northward toward the Himalayas and Mount Meru, accompanied by a dog.

One by one, they fall on the way. Draupadi falls first, because of her partiality toward Arjuna. Sahadeva falls because of pride in his wisdom, Nakula because of pride in his beauty, Arjuna because of pride in his skill, and Bhima because of gluttony and boasting.

Only Yudhishthira continues, along with the loyal dog. Each fall is explained as a human flaw that remained even in the best of people, showing that no one is entirely free from failings, and that the path to the highest goal demands complete detachment.

Svargarohana Parva: The Ascent to Heaven

Indra arrives with a chariot to take Yudhishthira to heaven, but declares that the dog cannot come. Yudhishthira refuses to abandon the dog and says he would rather give up heaven than a faithful companion. The dog is revealed as Dharma himself, who was testing him.

In heaven, Yudhishthira is shocked to see Duryodhana enthroned in glory, while his brothers and Draupadi are not there. He is taken to hell, where he hears their voices begging him to stay and ease their suffering. He chooses to stay with them.

It is then revealed to be an illusion, the final test. The gods explain that even a king must briefly see hell for the one deceit he used in the war, the half-truth about Ashwatthama. The Pandavas and their friends are reunited in heaven, and the epic closes, with the war's rivalries resolved.

The Pandavas

Yudhishthira, the eldest, is known for his devotion to truth and dharma, yet also for his fatal weakness for dice. Bhima, the second, is a man of immense physical strength, a master of the mace, with a fierce temper and a tender heart. Arjuna, the third, is the unrivalled archer and the friend and student of Krishna. Nakula and Sahadeva, the twins, are skilled in horses, cattle and astronomy, respectively.

Their mother Kunti received a mantra from the sage Durvasa that let her call upon any god to bear a child. Yudhishthira is son of Dharma, Bhima of Vayu, and Arjuna of Indra, while the twins, borne by Madri, are sons of the Ashvins. All five are married to Draupadi, born from a sacrificial fire, who is considered one of the epic's strongest and most complex female characters.

The Kauravas

The Kauravas are the hundred sons of Dhritarashtra and Gandhari. Duryodhana, the eldest, is a gifted warrior and a generous friend, but he is consumed by envy and a belief that the throne is his by right. His brother Duhshasana is a symbol of cruelty, remembered for his treatment of Draupadi.

Their uncle Shakuni, Gandhari's brother, is the master schemer who uses loaded dice and manipulation against the Pandavas. Dhritarashtra, blind to both sight and judgement, is torn between love for his son and recognition of justice, and ultimately fails to restrain Duryodhana. Gandhari, famously blindfolds herself in solidarity with her husband, yet she is also strongly principled, telling her son 'where there is dharma, there is victory.'

Krishna

Krishna, prince of the Yadavas and ruler of Dwaraka, is the central divine figure of the epic and is regarded in the tradition as an avatar of Vishnu. He is the cousin and friend of the Pandavas, and brother-in-law to Arjuna through his sister Subhadra.

He refuses to fight, serving as Arjuna's charioteer, and acts as advisor and strategist. His methods are sometimes controversial, as when he encourages stratagems that bend the rules of war, which he justifies as necessary to defeat adharma. His teachings to Arjuna in the Gita, and his appearances as peacemaker and cosmic being, make him the heart of the epic's spiritual vision.

Bhishma, Drona and Karna

Bhishma, the grand patriarch, is bound by his vow to serve whoever sits on the Hastinapura throne, and fights for the Kauravas despite loving the Pandavas. Drona, the teacher of the princes, is a brilliant but conflicted figure, driven by loyalty and by his rivalry with Drupada. His treatment of Ekalavya, whom he asked for a thumb as fee, is one of the epic's best-known ethical dilemmas.

Karna, born to Kunti before her marriage and raised by a charioteer, suffers rejection for his supposed low birth. Duryodhana's friendship gives him status, and he stays loyal to him to the end. He is famed for his generosity, his rivalry with Arjuna, and a tragic life shaped by curses and betrayals.

Women of the Mahabharata

Draupadi, Kunti, Gandhari, Satyavati, Ganga, Subhadra, and Uttara all shape the course of events. Draupadi challenges the court in the dice game, demanding to know whether Yudhishthira had the right to stake her after losing himself. Her vow to keep her hair loose until it is washed with Duhshasana's blood fuels the war.

Kunti's secret about Karna's birth carries enormous consequence, while Gandhari's curse forecasts Krishna's clan's end. Satyavati's choices launch the dynastic crisis. The epic gives these women agency, voice and moral weight, while also portraying the constraints placed on them.

The Bhagavad Gita

The Bhagavad Gita, 'the Song of the Lord', comprises 18 chapters and about 700 verses. It is presented as a dialogue between Arjuna and Krishna on the eve of battle. Arjuna's crisis, his reluctance to kill his teachers and kin, becomes a way to explore the question of how to act rightly in a world of conflict.

Krishna teaches that one has a right to action but not to its fruits, and describes several paths to liberation: karma yoga (selfless action), jnana yoga (knowledge), and bhakti yoga (devotion). He explains the immortality of the self and reveals his universal form. The Gita has become one of the most influential spiritual texts in the world.

Dharma and Moral Complexity

Dharma, meaning duty, righteousness and cosmic order, is the central theme. The epic does not offer simple answers. Characters on both sides break rules, and the heroes themselves bend or violate the codes of war. Yudhishthira's half-truth, Bhima's blow below the belt, and Arjuna's killing of Karna and Bhishma, all raise hard questions.

The text itself says that dharma is subtle and difficult to understand. It shows that good people can make terrible choices, that ends do not always justify means, and that war leaves no real winners. This ambiguity is one of the reasons the epic is still read and debated today.

Themes: Power, Loyalty, Fate and Justice

The Mahabharata examines the corrupting force of ambition, the pain of exclusion, and the weight of loyalty. Karna's fidelity to Duryodhana, Bhishma's to his vow, and Drona's to his son show how commitments can both ennoble and trap.

Fate and free will are in constant tension. Curses, boons and prophecies shape events, yet characters are held accountable for their choices. Justice is pursued through law, force, and sacrifice, but rarely feels complete.

The epic also reflects on friendship, family, gender and caste, and the limits of human knowledge. Its message is not tidy, but it consistently emphasises compassion, restraint and truth as guides.

Legacy and Adaptations

The Mahabharata has inspired art, literature, theatre and dance across South and Southeast Asia, from Javanese shadow puppetry to Kathakali and Yakshagana. Retellings range from C. Rajagopalachari's prose version and Irawati Karve's 'Yuganta' to Peter Brook's nine-hour stage production.

On screen, B. R. Chopra's 1988 television serial reached enormous audiences in India, and many films, animations, and recent series have followed. Modern novelists have reimagined the story from the perspective of women and marginal characters, such as Draupadi in 'The Palace of Illusions'.

Translations include the monumental critical edition produced at the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute in Pune, which is the scholarly standard.

Glossary of Key Terms

Dharma: duty, righteousness, cosmic law. Parva: a book or section of the epic. Kurukshetra: the battlefield, a plain in present-day Haryana. Svayamvara: a ceremony in which a bride chooses her husband. Akshauhini: a large military unit, with eighteen said to have fought in the war. Chakravyuha: a wheel-shaped military formation. Brahmastra: a powerful divine weapon.

Rajasuya: a royal consecration ritual. Ashvamedha: a horse sacrifice affirming imperial authority. Moksha: liberation from the cycle of birth and death. Yoga: in the Gita, a discipline or path. Avatar: a descent or incarnation of a deity. Rishi: a sage or seer. Rakshasa: a demon or supernatural being.